Six minutes to decide how to respond to a blip on a radar scope and decide whether to unleash Armageddon! How could anyone apply reason at a time like that?

There were some people in the Pentagon who thought in terms of fighting and *winning* a nuclear war. To me it was simple common sense: A nuclear war couldn't be won by either side. It must never be fought. But how do we go about trying to prevent it and pulling back from this hair-trigger existence?

During the spring of 1981, the arms race was moving ahead at a pell-mell pace based on the MAD policy. Investing a far larger portion of their national wealth on arms than we were, the Soviets were piling new weapon upon new weapon. We couldn't let them get ahead of us—so, in response to the Soviet threat, we were beginning a top-to-bottom modernization of our nuclear forces and getting ready to send a new family of intermediate-range weapons to Europe to help our NATO allies defend themselves against Soviet missiles.

There didn't seem any end to it, no way out of it.

Advocates of the MAD policy believed it had served a purpose: The balance of terror it created, they said, had prevented nuclear war for decades. But as far as I was concerned, the MAD policy was madness. For the first time in history, man had the power to destroy mankind itself. A war between the superpowers would incinerate much of the world and leave what was left of it uninhabitable forever.

There had to be some way to remove this threat of annihilation and give the world a greater chance of survival. That Sunday afternoon, as I went back and forth from these thoughts and working on my speech for Monday, I reflected that in the past, man had been able to devise a defense against every other weapon thrown against him. I wondered if it might be possible to develop a defense against missiles other than the fatalistic acceptance of annihilation that was